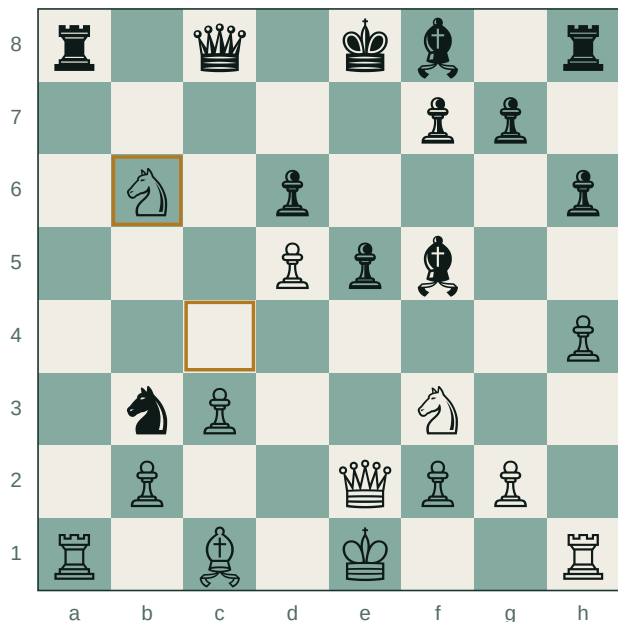


Loose-piece tactics: Black, move 20

Loose-piece tactics

Black to move



Previous move: 20.Nb6. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

20...Rxa1 21. Qb5+ Bd7

20...Rxa1 The rook captures the rook on a1. Recorded reply: **21.Qb5+**.

21...Bd7 The bishop moves from f5 to d7.

At the end, nominal material is White 29 / Black 33 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, Black's balance changes by +5. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does Black's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer: +5:** the balance goes from -1 to +4. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

A piece may appear hanging because its defender is indirect: taking it might allow mate, a fork, or a stronger capture.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

An undefended or tactically undefendable piece can turn an ordinary position into a combination. The first task is to distinguish a truly free capture from a poisoned one.

HOW TO LOOK

List the loose enemy pieces and check whether a forcing move can expose or attack more than one of them.

The defending king is on e1. Geometrically undefended: knight on b6 and rook on h1. Check for tactical protection.